



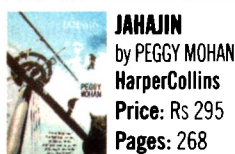
culture of their forebears in India. In the words of the narrator, "In the history books, it was the men who were the main actors. But there was also this unwritten history of the birth of a new community in Trinidad. And it was the women who were at the centre of the story."

The narrator translates with empathy and insight the taped conversations in Bhojpuri with *jahajins*, one of whom in particular, Deeda, is over a hundred years old and voyaged on the same ship that carried the narrator's great-great-grandmother. Their language is rich with idiom, and is fascinating due to its closeness to Hindi/Sanskrit, with many words delightfully familiar to the Indian reader. And as one would expect from a linguist, Mohan's ear for dialogue is accurate not just in the context of Bhojpuri, but also in the engaging way English slips into Trinidad patois. Here is the university-educated narrator ruminating over her future with her friend and colleague: "After! You know all these years I never really thought about it! I just figured I would find a university job abroad. But now that I almost finish my work I feel like is only now I getting to know this place."

This wonderfully rewarding read is a tale of loss and hope, of imaginary homelands and new foundations. And running like a golden thread through the narrative is the haunting legend of a beautiful maiden, Saranga, who spends her life trying to bind her lover, Sada Birij, to her for eternity. Seeking a coming together which reflects the yearning of the *jahajins* for the land of their birth—a yearning that also infuses the heart and imagination of the narrator. ■

Virgin Voyage

The women who migrated to Trinidad along with the farmers of north India are at the heart of this riveting tale of loss and hope



JAHAJIN
by PEGGY MOHAN
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 268

■ By Bunny Suraiya

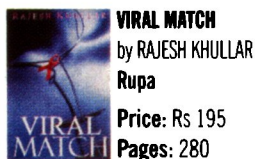
Ever since I fell madly in love at the age of 10 with Rohan Kanhai, the dashing West Indian cricketer, I've wondered off and on about the Indian emigration to the Caribbean. Who were these people with names like ours on the other side of the world? What made them go there?

Answers to these questions are provided by this riveting narrative, in which Peggy Mohan unravels the story of what is probably the earliest Indian diaspora. A linguist, Mohan (thinly disguised as an unnamed narrator) mastered Trinidad Bhojpuri in order to speak to the eponymous *jahajins*

(female sea-farers) who left their famished fields in what now comprises Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, to sign on as indentured labour at the sugar plantations in Trinidad, known to them as 'Chini-dad'. Men, women and children went in droves, first on foot to the nearest railheads, and then by train to the Calcutta docks, where they took the ship, the *jahaj*, on the long voyage around the tip of Africa, to wind up finally on a tiny island within shouting distance of South America.

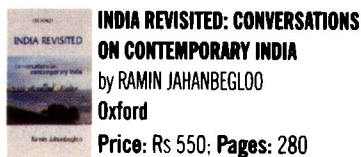
The significance of the women voyagers is that without their presence in the strange land, the Indian migrants would not have been able to form a community. Men on their own would have married into the local population and assimilated into the island's creole culture; it was the women—widows, unmarried girls and runaway wives—who carried along with them the language, cuisine and

NEW RELEASES



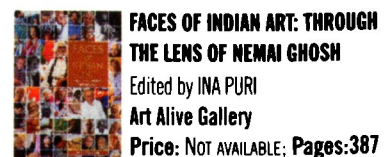
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Price: NOT AVAILABLE; Pages: 387

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